

Italian Quarterly, n. 10, autunno 1966

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The Onomastics of Pasinetti

(incipit)

Toward the middle of Pasinetti's novel *Rosso veneziano*, we find the clearest hint to the reader that the author has named his characters with special care. Giorgio has had an intriguing encounter with an attractive young woman whose name he has not learned; relating the experience to his friend Enrico, he says, however, that she "si chiama Blumenfeld," thus bringing the girl into the orbit of a whole Blumenfeld family long an object of charm and fascination for Giorgio. "Blumenfeld," he declares, è un nome bellissimo; ed è un nome al quale... mi sento molto intimamente legato.. Quel nome, Blumenfeld, l'ho offerto così, nell'immaginazione, a una ragazza ignota che m'è piaciuta, come avrei potuto offrire un fiore; il nome vuol appunto dire 'campo di fiori,' no?" (p. 295-96). ¹ This explication confirms what the reader has sensed from the beginning of the novel: the evocative power, the subtle resonances of Pasinetti's onomastics.

Take Partibon and Fassola, designating, as the author's preface points out, the two Venetian families, one of *artisti* and the other of *politici*, around whom the action of the novel is polarized. Both surnames are characteristically Venetian: the first, with its oxytonic accentuation; the second, with a root found frequently in Venice (an old telephone book for the city reveals Fassa, Fassetta, Fassi, Fassina, Fassini, Fasson - but no Fassola, for Pasinetti seems to have been extremely careful not to use real names). But there is more.

¹ All quotation from *Rosso veneziano* are taken from the 1959 edition (Casa editrice Carlo Colombo).